that created advanced distribution facilities for fresh vegetables and fruits across India.

Before the year ended, he unveiled a ‘roadmap for a massive expansion plan’ for Tata Chemicals, which included ‘acquisitions and greenfield projects, at an estimated investment of $1 billion over the next four years’. Both domestic and international markets were targeted, and the company looked at ‘emerging areas such as nano-technology, fermentation and bio-fuels’, which were explored at the company’s Innovation Centre in Maharashtra.

In 2008, Tata Chemicals acquired the US-based General Chemical Industrial Products (GCIP) for $1.05 billion or Rs 4,036 crore. This catapulted the company to the position of the world’s second-largest soda ash manufacturer. It brought scale and new customers to the company and led to a larger presence across geographies. It was a very strategic move by Ratan, according to Menon, as after the acquisition, Tata Chemicals became a ‘money spinner’, a ‘strong cash engine’ and commanded a greater market share in the US and South America markets.

It was a ‘mega move’, comments John Mulhall, MD, Tata Chemicals, North America, in keeping with Ratan’s goal of making Tata a global group. It gave Tata Chemicals access to a region that has immense natural resources, low-cost fuel in the form of natural gas and coal. In terms of scale the production of General Chemicals is nearly one and a half times more than the combined production of all the soda ash produced by Tata Chemicals in Kenya, England and India, he comments. In terms of the top line of Tata Chemicals, its contribution is substantial. In 2022, its share was nearly 30 per cent of the total revenue of the company. Mirroring Ratan’s philosophy, the company has also extended considerable support to the community around its four manufacturing units, assisting the elderly, disadvantaged children and mothers. Tata Chemicals is now ‘more focused’ on increasing its contributions to the community by giving it a proportion of the profits it makes, reveals Mulhall.

Deeply concerned about environmental issues, Ratan had an abiding interest in promoting environment-friendly fuels. When the opportunity dawned, Tata Chemicals acquired a 35 per cent stake in the Singapore-based jatropha (biofuel crop) seedling company, Joil (S) Pte, for $25 million. He also shared his philosophy behind the acquisitions, revealing his legendary vision, by saying that the various overseas acquisitions ‘gave